

New Concept English Book 3

60 articles

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1. A Puma at large

Pumas are large, cat - like animals which are found in America. When reports came into London Zoo that a wild puma had been spotted forty - five miles south of London, they were not taken seriously. However, as the evidence began to accumulate, experts from the Zoo felt obliged to investigate, for the descriptions given by people who claimed to have seen the puma were extraordinarily similar.

The hunt for the puma began in a small village where a woman picking blackberries saw 'a large cat' only five yards away from her. It immediately ran away when she saw it, and experts confirmed that a puma will not attack a human being unless it is cornered. The search proved difficult, for the puma was often observed at one place in the morning and at another place twenty miles away in the evening. Wherever it went, it left behind it a trail of dead deer and small animals like rabbits.

Footprints were seen in a number of places and puma fur was found clinging to bushes. Several people claimed to have seen the puma at different times, but they all agreed that it was a large cat with a long tail and a light - brown coat. All the evidence pointed to the fact that the puma was in the area.

In the end, the mystery was solved when the puma was caught by a farmer in a trap. It was a young puma which had strayed from its mother and decided to go exploring on its own. It must have been in the area for some time, for it had already eaten some of the deer and small animals that were in the area. It was taken to London Zoo, where it lived for several months before it died.

2. Thirteen Equals One

Our vicar is always raising money for one cause or another, but he has never managed to get enough money to have the church clock repaired. The big clock which used to strike the hours day and night was damaged many years ago and has been silent ever since.

One night, however, our vicar woke up with a start: the clock was striking the hours! Looking at his watch, he saw that it was one o'clock, but the bell struck thirteen times before it stopped. Armed with a torch, the vicar went up into the clock tower to see what was going on. In the torchlight, he caught sight of a figure whom he immediately recognized as Bill Wilkins, our local grocer.

'Whatever are you doing up here Bill?' asked the vicar in surprise.

'I'm trying to repair the bell,' answered Bill. 'I've been coming up here night after night for weeks now. You see, I was hoping to give you a surprise.'

'You certainly did give me a surprise!' said the vicar. 'You've probably woken up everyone in the village as well. Still, I'm glad the bell is working again.'

'That's the trouble, vicar,' answered Bill. 'It's working all right, but I'm afraid that at one o'clock it will strike thirteen times and there's nothing I can do about it.'

We shall have to get the bell fixed, said the vicar, 'but not yet.

I'm afraid it will not be over until the last stroke has been struck. And the last stroke may not be for some time yet.'

3. An unknown goddess

Some time ago, an interesting discovery was made by archaeologists on the Aegean island of Kea. An American team explored a temple which stands in an ancient city on the promontory of Ayia Irini. The city at one time must have been prosperous, for it enjoyed a high level of civilization. Houses -- often three storeys high -- were built of stone. They had large rooms with beautifully decorated walls. The city was even equipped with a drainage system, for a great many clay pipes were found beneath the narrow streets.

The temple which the archaeologists explored was used as a place of worship from the fifteenth century B.C. until Roman times. In the most sacred room of the temple, clay fragments of fifteen statues were found. Each of these represented a goddess and had, at one time, been painted. The body of one statue was found among remains dating from the fifteenth century B.C. Its missing head happened to be among remains of the fifth century B.C.

This head must have been found in Classical times and carefully preserved. It was very old and precious even then. When the archaeologists reconstructed the fragments, they were amazed to find that the goddess turned out to be a very modern - looking woman. She stood three feet high and her hands rested on her hips. She was wearing a full - length skirt which swept the ground. Despite her great age, she was very graceful indeed, but, so far, the archaeologists have been unable to discover her identity.

4. The double life of Alfred Bloggs

These days, people who do manual work often receive far more money than people who work in offices. People who work in offices are frequently referred to as 'white - collar workers' for the simple reason that they usually wear a collar and tie to go to work. Such is human nature, that a great many people are often willing to sacrifice higher pay for the privilege of becoming white - collar workers. This can give rise to curious situations, as it did in the case of Alfred Bloggs who worked as a dustman for the Ellesmere Corporation.

When he got married, Alf was too embarrassed to say anything to his wife about his job. He simply told her that he worked for the Corporation. Every morning, he left home dressed in a smart black suit. He then changed into overalls and spent the next eight hours as a dustman. Before returning home at night, he took a shower and changed back into his suit. Alf did this for over two years and his fellow dustmen kept his secret. Alf's wife has never discovered that she married a dustman and she never will, for Alf has just found another job. He will soon be working in an office. He will be earning only half as much as he used to, but he feels that his rise in status is well worth the loss of money.

5. The facts

Editors of newspapers and magazines often go to extremes to provide their readers with unimportant facts and statistics. Last year a journalist had been instructed by a well - known magazine to write an article on the president's palace in a new African republic. When the article arrived, the editor read the first sentence and then refused to publish it. The article began: 'Hundreds of steps lead to the high wall which surrounds the president's palace.' The editor at once sent the journalist a fax instructing him to find out the exact number of steps and the height of the wall.

The journalist immediately set out to obtain these important facts, but he took a long time to send them. Meanwhile, the editor was getting impatient, for the magazine would soon go to press. He sent the journalist two more faxes, but received no reply. He sent yet another fax informing the journalist that if he did not reply soon he would be fired. When the journalist finally replied, he said that he had been arrested while counting the steps in front of the president's palace. The police had told him that he was not allowed to park his car there. As he had no place to stay, he decided to spend the night in the station. He counted the steps again, and then the height of the wall. When he got home, he sent the editor the facts as he had promised.

6. Smash-and-grab

The expensive shops in a famous arcade near Piccadilly were just opening. At this time of the morning, the arcade was almost empty. Mr Taylor, the owner of a jewellery shop was admiring a new window display. Two of his assistants had been working busily since 8 o'clock and had only just finished. Diamond necklaces and rings had been beautifully arranged on a background of black velvet. After gazing at the display for several minutes, Mr Taylor went back into his shop.

The silence was suddenly broken when a large car, with its headlights on and its horn blaring, roared down the arcade. It came to a stop outside the jeweller's. One man stayed at the wheel while two others with black stockings over their faces jumped out and smashed the window of the shop with iron bars. While this was going on, Mr Taylor was upstairs. He and his staff began throwing furniture out of the window. Chairs and tables went flying into the arcade. One of the thieves was struck by a heavy statue, but he was too busy helping himself to diamonds to notice any pain. The raid was all over in three minutes, for the men scrambled back into the car and it moved off at a fantastic speed. Just as it was leaving, Mr Taylor rushed out and ran after it throwing ashtrays and vases, but it was impossible to stop the thieves. They had got away with thousands of pounds worth of diamonds.

7. Mutilated ladies

Has it ever happened to you? Have you ever put your trousers in the washing machine and then remembered there was a large bank note in your back pocket? When you rescued your trousers, did you find the note was whiter than white? People who live in Britain needn't despair when they make mistakes like this (and a lot of people do)! Fortunately for them, the Bank of England has a team called Mutilated Ladies which deals with claims from people who fed their money to a machine or to their dog. Dogs, it seems, love to chew up money!

A recent case concerns Jane Butlin whose fiancé, John, runs a successful furniture business. John had a very good day and put his wallet containing £3,000 into the microwave oven for safekeeping. Then he and Jane went horse - riding. When they got home, Jane cooked their dinner in the microwave oven and without realizing it, cooked her fiancé's wallet as well. Imagine their dismay when they found a beautifully - cooked wallet and notes turned to ash! John went to see his bank manager who sent the remains of wallet and the money to the special department of the Bank of England in Newcastle: the Mutilated Ladies! They examined the remains and John got all his money back. 'So

long as there's something to identify, we will give people their money back,' said a spokeswoman for the Bank. 'Last year, we paid out over £1.5m on 21,000 claims.'

8. A famous monastery

The Great St. Bernard Pass connects Switzerland to Italy. At 2,473 metres, it is the highest mountain pass in Europe. The famous monastery of St. Bernard, which was founded in the eleventh century, lies about a mile away. For hundreds of years, St. Bernard dogs have saved the lives of travellers crossing the dangerous Pass. These friendly dogs, which were first brought from Asia, were used as watch - dogs even in Roman times. Now that a tunnel has been built through the mountains, the Pass is less dangerous, but each year, the dogs are still sent out into the snow whenever a traveller is in difficulty. Despite the new tunnel, there are still a few people who rashly attempt to cross the Pass on foot.

During the summer months, the monastery is very busy, for it is visited by thousands of people who cross the Pass in cars. As there are so many people about, the dogs have to be kept in a special enclosure. In winter, however, life at the monastery is quite different. The temperature drops to - 30 and very few people attempt to cross the Pass. The monks prefer winter to summer for they have more privacy. The dogs have greater freedom, too, for they are allowed to wander outside their enclosure. The only regular visitors to the monastery in winter are parties of skiers who go there at Christmas and Easter. These young people, who love the peace of the mountains, always receive a warm welcome at St. Bernard's monastery.

9. Flying Cats

Cats never fail to fascinate human beings. They can be friendly and affectionate towards humans, but they lead mysterious lives of their own as well. They never become submissive in the way that dogs and horses do, and they seem to have a mysterious intelligence of their own.

Some cats are reputed to have remarkable powers of perception and are able to sense the approach of thunderstorms long before they break. This feline sensitivity to one of the principle forces of nature has been used to explain certain phenomena which otherwise remain inexplicable. For instance, a cat is said to instinctively know which room in a house contains its mistress without ever having entered it. In one instance which has been reported, a cat left his house, crossed several roads, climbed a fence, proceeded along the

top of the fence, entered a neighbor's garden, and walked straight into their house to a room where the owner was sleeping, just in time to wake her up when a fire had just broken out. (There were some people who thought that this was all part of an elaborate plot!) There are also stories about cats who supposedly have the power to predict earthquakes. Japanese researchers have been able to make their own cats misbehave just by giving them a tiny electric shock: they have been trying to find out whether cats can really detect earthquakes early or whether it was a false alarm.

Most of us have seen cats rubbing their faces against the legs of the people they live with or curling up in their laps. They do this not only to be affectionate but also to mark out their territory. When cats are communicating with each other, they use a variety of different vocalizations as well as a whole range of body postures and facial expressions. They spit, hiss and growl when they are angry or frightened. They arch their backs and make their fur stand on end when they feel threatened. They purr when they are contented. The language of cats is still only partly understood by humans, but it is obvious that they have a complex system of communication.

Cats also have a very accurate sense of time. They know when it is time to get up, when it is time to go to bed, and when it is time to eat. They are also very good at finding their way home. Even if they are taken to a strange place many miles away, they are able to find their way back to their original home. This homing instinct, as it is called, is still not fully understood by scientists, but it is thought to be related to the cat's highly developed sense of smell and its ability to recognize certain landmarks.

Finally, cats are very good at taking care of themselves. They groom themselves constantly, licking their fur clean and removing any dirt or parasites. They also keep their claws sharp by scratching on suitable surfaces. This self - care is important for their survival, because cats are solitary animals and they have to be able to look after themselves in the wild.

10. The Loss of the Titanic

The great ship, Titanic, sailed for New York from Southampton on April 10th, 1912. She was carrying 1,316 passengers and a crew of 891. Even by modern standards, the 46,000 ton Titanic was a colossal ship. At that time, however, she was not only the largest ship that had ever been built, but was regarded as unsinkable, for she had sixteen watertight compartments. Even if two of these were flooded, she would still be able to float. The tragic sinking of this great liner will always be remembered, for she went down on her first voyage with heavy loss of life.

Four days after setting out, while the Titanic was sailing across the icy waters of the North Atlantic, a huge iceberg was suddenly spotted by a lookout. After the alarm had been given, the great ship turned sharply to avoid a direct collision. The Titanic turned just in time, narrowly missing the immense wall of ice which rose over 100 feet out of the water beside her. Suddenly, there was a slight trembling sound from below, and the captain went down to see what had happened. The noise had been so faint that no one thought that the ship had been damaged. Below, the captain realized to his horror that the Titanic was sinking rapidly, for five of her sixteen watertight compartments had already been flooded! The order to abandon ship was given and hundreds of people plunged into the icy water. As there were not enough lifeboats for everybody, 1,500 lives were lost.

11. Not Guilty

Customs Officers are quite tolerant these days. They are paid to turn a blind eye to things. Only a few, like Sergeant Custard, earn their pay by being eagle-eyed. One such officer was Tim Smith, who controlled the southern frontier of the city. He had a reputation for being tough on smugglers. Every day he would see a lorry load of goods pass through his area and he was always suspicious. He often had a hunch that something was wrong, even when there was no evidence to support his feeling. One day, he noticed a small van which was parked outside a large store. It was early in the morning and the van was unoccupied. Smith decided to keep an eye on it. As the day progressed, he saw people coming and going from the store, but no one went near the van. By lunchtime, Smith was really beginning to wonder what was going on. Then, just after lunch, a man came out of the store, walked over to the van and opened the back door. Smith immediately rushed over. 'What are you doing?' he demanded. 'I'm just making a delivery,' the man replied. 'Oh, really?' said Smith. 'Then why has this van been sitting here all morning with no one near it?' 'I don't know,' said the man. 'I'm just following my orders.' Smith was not convinced. He decided to search the van. He found nothing suspicious inside. Just as he was about to give up, he noticed a small compartment under the floor. He opened it and found a large quantity of cigarettes. 'What's this?' he asked the man. 'I - I don't know,' stammered the man. 'It's not mine.' 'Well, it's in your van,' said Smith. 'You're under arrest for smuggling.' 'But I'm not guilty,' protested the man. 'I didn't put those cigarettes there.' 'Then who did?' asked Smith. 'I don't know,' said the man. 'I'm just a delivery man.' Smith took the man to the police station. There, he was questioned further. But he still maintained his innocence. In the end, the police had to let him go. They had no evidence to prove that he was guilty. Smith was disappointed. He had been so sure that the man was a smuggler. But he had to admit that he had been wrong. He learned a valuable lesson that day: not

to jump to conclusions.

12. Life on a Desert Island

Most of us have formed an unrealistic picture of life on a desert island. We sometimes imagine a desert island to be a sort of paradise where the sun always shines. Life there is simple and good. Ripe fruit falls from the trees and you never have to work. The other side of the picture is quite the opposite. Life on a desert island is wretched. You either starve to death or live like Robinson Crusoe, waiting for a boat which never comes. Perhaps there is an element of truth in both these pictures, but few of us have had the opportunity to find out. Two men who recently spent five days on a coral island wished they had stayed there longer. They were taking a badly damaged boat from the Virgin Islands to Miami to have it repaired. During the journey, their boat began to sink. They quickly loaded a small rubber dinghy with food, matches, and cans of beer and rowed for a few miles across the Caribbean until they arrived at a tiny coral island. There were hardly any trees on the island and there was no water, but this did not prove to be a problem. The men collected rain - water in the rubber dinghy. As they had brought a spear gun with them, they had plenty of food. They caught lobster and fish every day, and, as one of them put it 'ate like kings'. When a passing tanker rescued them five days later, both men were genuinely sorry that they had to leave.

13. It's only me

After her husband had gone to work. Mrs. Richards sent her children to school and went upstairs to her bedroom. She was too excited to do any housework that morning, for in the evening she would be going to a fancy - dress party with her husband. She intended to dress up as a ghost and as she had made her costume the night before, she was impatient to try it on. Though the costume consisted only of a sheet, it was very effective. After putting it on, Mrs. Richards went downstairs. She wanted to find out whether it would be comfortable to wear.

Just as Mrs. Richards was entering the dining room, there was a knock on the front door. She knew that it must be the baker. She had told him to come straight in if ever she failed to open the door and to leave the bread on the kitchen table. Not wanting to frighten the poor man, Mrs. Richards quickly hid in the small storeroom under the stairs.

She heard the front door open and heavy footsteps in the hall. Suddenly the door of the

storeroom was opened and a man entered. Mrs. Richards realized that it must be the baker. She coughed to draw his attention to her presence, but the man did not look up. Instead, he just stared at her, then he let out a cry and jumped back several feet. When Mrs. Richards walked towards him, he fled, slamming the door behind him.

Mrs. Richards was astonished. Then she smiled as she realized that the man was blind. He had come to read the meter.

14. A noble gangster

There was a time when the owners of shops and businesses in Chicago had to pay large sums of money to gangsters in return for 'protection'. If the money was not paid promptly, the gangsters would quickly put a man out of business by destroying his shop. Obtaining 'protection money' is not a modern crime. As long ago as the fourteenth century, an Englishman, Sir John Hawkwood, made the remarkable discovery that people would rather pay large sums of money than have their life work destroyed by gangsters.

Six hundred years ago, Sir John Hawkwood arrived in Italy with a band of soldiers and settled near Florence. He soon made a name for himself and came to be known to the Italians as Giovanni Acuto. Whenever the Italian city - states were at war with each other, Hawkwood used to hire his soldiers to princes who were willing to pay the high price he demanded. In times of peace, when business was bad, Hawkwood and his men would march into a city - state and, after burning down a few farms, would offer to go away if protection money was paid to them. Hawkwood made large sums of money in this way. In spite of this, the Italians regarded him as a sort of hero. When he died at the age of eighty, the Florentines gave him a state funeral and had a picture painted which was dedicated to the memory of 'the most valiant soldier and most notable leader, Signor Giovanni Acuto'.

15. Fifty pence worth of trouble

Children always appreciate small gifts of money. Father, of course, provides a regular supply of pocket-money, but uncles and aunts are always a source of extra income. With some children, small sums go a long way. If sixpences are not exchanged for sweets, they rattle for months inside money-boxes. Only very thrifty children manage to fill up a money - box. For most of them, sixpence is a small price to pay for a satisfying bar of chocolate.

My nephew, George, has a money-box but it is always empty. Very few of the sixpences I have given him have found their way there. I gave him sixpence yesterday and advised him to save it. Instead, he bought himself sixpence worth of trouble.

On his way to the sweet - shop, he dropped his sixpence and it rolled along the pavement and then disappeared down a drain.

George took off his jacket, rolled up his sleeves and pushed his right arm through the drain cover. He could not find his sixpence anywhere, and what is more, he could not get his arm out. A crowd of people gathered round him and a lady rubbed his arm with soap and butter, but George was firmly stuck.

The fire - brigade was called and two firemen freed George using a special type of grease. George was not too upset by his experience because the lady who owns the sweet shop heard about his troubles and rewarded him with a large box of chocolates.

16. Mary had a Little Lamb

Mary and her husband Dimitri lived in the tiny village of Perachora in southern Greece. One of Mary's prize possessions was a little white lamb which her husband had given her. She kept it tied to a tree in a field during the day and went to fetch it every evening. One evening, however, the lamb was missing. The rope had been cut, so it was obvious that the lamb had been stolen.

When Dimitri came in from the fields, his wife told him what had happened. Dimitri at once set out to find the thief. He knew it would not prove difficult in such a small village. After telling several of his friends about the theft, Dimitri found out that his neighbour, Aleko, had suddenly acquired a new lamb. Dimitri immediately went to Aleko's house and angrily accused him of stealing the lamb. He told him he had better return it or he would call the police. Aleko denied taking it and led Dimitri into his backyard. It was true that he had just bought a lamb, he explained, but his lamb was black. Ashamed of having acted so rashly, Dimitri apologized to Aleko for having accused him. While they were talking it began to rain and Dimitri stayed in Aleko's house until the rain stopped. When he went outside half an hour later, he was astonished to find that the little black lamb was almost white. Its wool, which had been dyed black, had been washed clean by the rain!

17. The longest suspension bridge in the world

Verrazano, an Italian about whom little is known, sailed into New York Harbour in 1524 and named it Angouleme. He described it as 'a very agreeable situation located within two small hills in the midst of which flowed a great river.' Though Verrazano is by no means considered to be a great explorer, his name will probably remain immortal, for on November 21st, 1964, the longest suspension bridge in the world was named after him.

The Verrazano Bridge, which was designed by Othmar Ammann, joins Brooklyn to Staten Island. It has a span of 4,260 feet. The bridge is so long that the shape of the earth had to be taken into account by its designer. Two great towers support four huge cables. The towers are built on immense underwater platforms made of steel and concrete. The platforms extend to a depth of over 100 feet under the sea. These alone took sixteen months to build. Above the surface of the water, the towers rise to a height of nearly 700 feet. They support the cables from which the bridge has been suspended. Each of the four cables contains 26,108 lengths of wire. It has been estimated that if the bridge were packed with cars, it would still only be carrying a third of its total capacity. However, size and strength are not the only important things about this bridge. Despite its immensity, it is both simple and elegant, fulfilling its designer's dream to create 'an enormous object drawn as faintly as possible'.

18. Electric Currents in Modern Art

Modern sculpture rarely surprises us any more. The idea that modern art can only be seen in museums is mistaken. Even people who take no interest in art cannot have failed to notice examples of modern sculpture on display in public places. Strange forms stand in gardens, and outside buildings and shops. We have got quite used to them. Some so-called 'modern' pieces have been on display for nearly eighty years.

In spite of this, some people - including myself - were surprised by a recent exhibition of modern sculpture. The first thing I saw when I entered the art gallery was a notice which said: 'Do not touch the exhibits. Some of them are dangerous!' The objects on display were pieces of moving sculpture. Oddly shaped forms that are suspended from the ceiling and move in response to a gust of wind are quite familiar to everybody. These objects, however, were different. Lined up against the wall, there were long thin wires attached to metal spheres. The spheres had been magnetized and attracted or repelled each other all the time. In the centre of the hall, there were a number of tall structures which contained coloured lights. These lights flickered continuously like traffic lights which have gone mad. Sparks were emitted from small black boxes and red lamps flashed on and off angrily. It

was rather like an exhibition of pre - historic electronic equipment. These peculiar forms not only seemed designed to shock people emotionally, but to give them electric shocks as well!

I soon learnt about all the tricks of the trade. Early in the morning, we were told, there is a large pool of water in the centre of the hall which reflects the sculptures. This, apparently, is to give the illusion that the sculptures are floating in mid - air. Next to the pool there is a deep pit with a ladder, so that visitors can descend into it and experience these curious sculptures more fully. There is also an art gallery in the pit, which displays some modern paintings. The paintings look so real that they seem to be floating on the wall. I was so intrigued by these works of art that I decided to buy a catalogue. As I was leaving, I noticed that all the visitors were given a small electric shock as they passed through the turnstile. It was a most unusual exhibition.

19. A Very Dear Cat

Kidnappers are rarely interested in animals, but they recently took considerable interest in Mrs. Eleanor Ramsay's cat. Mrs. Eleanor Ramsay, a very wealthy old lady, has shared a flat with her cat, Rastus, for a great many years. Rastus leads an orderly life. He usually takes a short walk in the evenings and is always home by seven o'clock. One evening, however, he failed to arrive. Mrs. Ramsay got very worried. She looked everywhere for him but could not find him.

Three days after Rastus' disappearance, Mrs. Ramsay received an anonymous letter. The writer stated that Rastus was in safe hands and would be returned immediately if Mrs. Ramsay paid a ransom of £1,000. Mrs. Ramsay was instructed to place the money in a cardboard box and to leave it outside her door. At first, she decided to go to the police, but fearing that she would never see Rastus again - the letter had made that quite clear - she changed her mind. She drew £1,000 from her bank and followed the kidnapper's instructions. The next morning, the box had disappeared but Mrs. Ramsay was sure that the kidnapper would keep his word. Sure enough, Rastus arrived punctually at seven o'clock that evening. He looked very well, though he was rather thirsty, for he drank half a bottle of milk. The police were astounded when Mrs. Ramsay told them what she had done. She explained that Rastus was very dear to her. Considering the amount she paid, he was dear in more ways than one!

20. Pioneer Pilots

In 1908 Lord Northcliffe offered a prize of £1,000 to the first man who would fly across the English Channel.

Over a year passed before the first attempt was made.

On July 19th, 1909, in the early morning, Hubert Latham took off from the French coast in his plane the 'Antoinette IV' .

He had travelled only seven miles across the Channel when his engine failed and he was forced to land on the sea.

The 'Antoinette' floated on the water until Latham was picked up by a ship.

Two days later, Louis Bleriot arrived near Calais with a plane called 'No. XI' .

Bleriot had been making planes since 1905 and this was his latest model.

A week before, he had completed a successful overland flight during which he covered twenty - six miles.

Latham, however, did not give up easily.

He, too, arrived near Calais on the same day with a new 'Antoinette' .

It looked as if there would be an exciting race across the Channel.

Both planes were going to take off on July 25th, but Latham failed to get up early enough.

After making a short test flight at 4.15 a.m., Bleriot set off half an hour later.

His great flight lasted thirty - seven minutes.

When he landed near Dover, the first person to greet him was a local policeman.

Latham made another attempt a week later and got within half a mile of Dover, but he was unlucky again.

His engine failed and he landed on the sea for the second time.

21. Daniel Mendoza

Boxing matches were very popular in England two hundred years ago. In those days, boxers fought with bare fists for prize money. Because of this, they were known as 'prize - fighters'. However, boxing was very crude, for there were no rules and a prize - fighter could be seriously injured or even killed during a match.

One of the most colourful figures in boxing history was Daniel Mendoza, who was born in 1764. The use of gloves was not introduced until 1860, when the Marquis of Queensberry

drew up the first set of rules. Though he was technically a prize - fighter, Mendoza did much to change crude prize - fighting into a sport, for he brought science to the game. In his day, Mendoza enjoyed tremendous popularity. He was adored by rich and poor alike.

Mendoza rose to fame swiftly after a boxing - match when he was only fourteen years old. This attracted the attention of Richard Humphries who was then the most eminent boxer in England. He offered to train Mendoza and his young pupil was quick to learn. In fact, Mendoza soon became so successful that Humphries turned against him. The two men quarrelled bitterly and it was clear that the argument could only be settled by a fight. A match was held at Stilton, where both men fought for an hour. The public bet a great deal of money on Mendoza, but he was defeated. Mendoza met Humphries in the ring on a later occasion and he lost for a second time.

It was not until his third match in 1790 that he finally beat Humphries and became Champion of England. Meanwhile, he founded a highly successful Academy and even Lord Byron became one of his pupils. He earned enormous sums of money and was paid as much as 100 pounds for a single appearance. Despite this, he was so extravagant that he was always in debt. After he was defeated by a boxer called Gentleman Jackson, he was quickly forgotten. He was sent to prison for failing to pay his debts and died in poverty in 1836.

22. By Heart

Some plays are so successful that they run for years on end. In many ways, this is unfortunate for the poor actors who are required to go on repeating the same lines night after night. One would expect them to know their parts by heart and never have cause to falter. Yet this is not always the case.

A famous actor in a highly successful play was once cast in the role of an aristocrat who had been imprisoned in the Bastille for twenty years. In the last act, a gaoler would always come on to the stage with a letter which he would hand to the prisoner. Even though the noble was expected to read the letter at each performance, he always insisted that it should be written out in full.

One night, the gaoler decided to play a joke on his colleague to find out if, after so many performances, he had managed to learn the contents of the letter by heart. The curtain went up on the final act of the play and revealed the aristocrat sitting alone behind bars in his dark cell. Just then, the gaoler appeared with the precious letter in his hands. He entered the cell and presented the letter to the aristocrat. But the copy he gave him had not been written out in full as usual. It was simply a blank sheet of paper. The gaoler

looked on eagerly, anxious to see if his fellow - actor had at last learnt his lines. The noble stared at the blank sheet of paper for a few seconds. Then, squinting his eyes, he said: 'The light is dim. Read the letter to me.' And he promptly handed the sheet of paper back to the gaoler. Finding that he could not remember a word of the letter either, the gaoler replied: 'The light is indeed dim, sire. I must get my glasses.' With this, he hurried off the stage. Much to the aristocrat's amusement, the gaoler returned a few moments later with a pair of glasses and the usual copy of the letter which he proceeded to read to the prisoner.

23. One Man's Meat is Another Man's Poison

People become quite illogical when they try to decide what can be eaten and what cannot be eaten. If you lived in the Mediterranean, for instance, you would consider octopus a great delicacy. You would not be able to understand why some people find it repulsive. On the other hand, your stomach would turn at the idea of frying potatoes in animal fat -- the normally accepted practice in many northern countries. The sad truth is that most of us have been brought up to eat certain foods and we stick to them all our lives.

No creature has received more praise and abuse than the common garden snail. Cooked in wine, snails are a great luxury in various parts of the world. There are countless people who, ever since their early years, have learned to associate snails with food. My friend, Robert, lives in a country where snails are despised. As his flat is in a large town, he has no garden of his own. For years he has been asking me to collect snails from my garden and take them to him.

The idea never appealed to me very much, but one day, after a heavy shower, I happened to be walking in my garden when I noticed a huge number of snails taking a stroll on some of my prize plants. Acting on impulse, I collected several dozen, put them in a paper bag, and took them to Robert. Robert was delighted to see me and equally pleased with my little gift. I left the bag in the hall and Robert and I went into the living room where we talked for a couple of hours. I had forgotten all about the snails when Robert suddenly said that I must stay to dinner. Snails would, of course, be the main dish. I did not fancy the idea and I reluctantly followed Robert out of the living room. To my dismay, I saw that there were snails everywhere: they had escaped from the paper bag and had taken complete possession of the hall! I have never been able to look at a snail since then.

24. A skeleton in the cupboard

We often read in novels how a seemingly respectable person or family has some terrible secret which has been concealed from strangers for years. The English language possesses a vivid saying to describe this sort of situation. The terrible secret is called 'a skeleton in the cupboard'. At some dramatic moment in the story, the terrible secret becomes known and a reputation is ruined. The reader's hair stands on end when he reads in the final pages of the novel that the heroine, a dear old lady who had always been so kind to everybody, had, in her youth, poisoned every one of her five husbands.

It is all very well for such things to occur in fiction. To varying degrees, we all have secrets which we do not want even our closest friends to learn, but few of us have skeletons in the cupboard. The only person I know who has a skeleton in the cupboard is George Carlton, and he is very proud of the fact. George studied medicine in his youth. Instead of becoming a doctor, however, he became a successful writer of detective stories. I once spent an uncomfortable weekend which I shall never forget at his house. George showed me to the guestroom which, he said, was very quiet, but I was horrified to find that it looked out onto a cemetery.

'Oh, that's all right,' George said when I told him how I felt. 'I don't mind the view at all.' That was the start of an uncomfortable weekend. The first night, I had scarcely closed my eyes when a strange little man appeared at my bedside. 'I'm sorry to disturb you,' he said, 'but I think there is something wrong with my stomach.' I was in no mood to pass a pleasantry with him, so I simply stared at him until he went away. The next morning I got up early. I had a good breakfast and a pleasant morning stroll. After lunch, I settled down to read in the garden, but the book I was reading could not hold my attention. Every few minutes I raised my head to look at the view. It was not a pleasant view. I decided to go for a walk. I had not gone far when I saw a figure in the distance. I recognized George. He was walking slowly towards me. When he came near, I noticed that he looked very pale. 'I'm sorry to have troubled you last night,' he said. 'I had a bad night myself. I thought I heard something moving in the cupboard. It was probably a mouse, but it sounded like a skeleton. I'm not used to having skeletons in the cupboard, you know.'

25. The Cutty Sark

One of the most famous sailing ships of the nineteenth century, the Cutty Sark, can still be seen at Greenwich. She stands on dry land and is visited by thousands of people each year. She serves as an impressive reminder of the great ships of the past. Before they were replaced by steam-ships, sailing vessels like the Cutty Sark were used to carry tea from

China and wool from Australia. The Cutty Sark was one of the fastest sailing ships that has ever been built. The only other ship to match her was the Thermopylae. Both these ships set out from Shanghai on June 18th, 1872 on an exciting race to England. This race, which went on for exactly four months, was the last of its kind. It marked the end of the great tradition of ships with sails and the beginning of a new era. The first of the two ships to reach Java after the race had begun was the Thermopylae, but on the Indian Ocean, the Cutty Sark took the lead. It seemed certain that she would be the first ship home, but during the race she had a lot of bad luck. In August, she was struck by a very heavy storm during which her rudder was torn away. The Cutty Sark rolled from side to side and it became impossible to steer her. A temporary rudder was made on board from spare planks and it was fitted with great difficulty. This greatly reduced the speed of the ship, for there was a danger that if she travelled too quickly, this rudder would be torn away as well. Because of this, the Cutty Sark lost her lead. After crossing the Equator, the captain called in at a port to have a new rudder fitted, but by now the Thermopylae was over five hundred miles ahead. Though the new rudder was fitted at tremendous speed, it was impossible for the Cutty Sark to win. She arrived in England a week after the Thermopylae. Even this was remarkable, considering that she had had so many delays. There is no doubt that if she had not lost her rudder she would have won the race easily.

After she had been retired, she was put on display in Greenwich in 1954. A great deal of work was done to restore her, and she is now in perfect condition. Even though she was never actually sailed, the Cutty Sark remains one of the most famous ships of all time.

26. Wanted: a large biscuit tin

No one can avoid being influenced by advertisements. Much as we may pride ourselves on our good taste, we are no longer free to choose the things we want, for advertising exerts a subtle influence on us. In their efforts to persuade us to buy this or that product, advertisers have made a close study of human nature and have classified all our little weaknesses.

Advertisers discovered years ago that all of us love to get something for nothing. An advertisement which begins with the magic word FREE can rarely go wrong. These days, advertisers not only offer free samples, but free cars, free houses, and free trips round the world as well. They devise hundreds of competitions which will enable us to win huge sums of money. Radio and television have made it possible for advertisers to capture the attention of millions of people in this way.

During a radio programme, a company of biscuit manufacturers once asked listeners to bake biscuits and send them to their factory. They offered to pay \$10 a pound for the

biggest biscuit baked by a listener. The response to this competition was tremendous. Before long, biscuits of all shapes and sizes began arriving at the factory. One lady brought in a biscuit on a wheelbarrow. It weighed nearly 500 pounds. A little later, a man came along with a biscuit which occupied the whole of his car boot. All the biscuits that were sent were carefully weighed. The largest was 713 pounds. It seemed certain that this would win the prize. But just before the competition closed, a lorry arrived at the factory with a truly colossal biscuit which weighed 2,400 pounds. It had been baked by a college student who had used over 1,000 pounds of flour, 800 pounds of sugar, 200 pounds of fat, and 400 pounds of various other ingredients. It was so large that the lorry that carried it could barely move. The manufacturers had to pay more than they had anticipated, for they bought the biscuit from the student for \$24,000.

27. Nothing to Sell and Nothing to Buy

It has been said that everyone lives by selling something. In the light of this statement, teachers live by selling knowledge, philosophers by selling wisdom and priests by selling spiritual comfort. Though it may be possible to measure the value of material goods in terms of money, it is extremely difficult to estimate the true value of the services which people perform for us. There are times when we would willingly give everything we possess to save our lives, yet we might grudge paying a surgeon a high fee for offering us precisely this service. The conditions of society are such that skills have to be paid for in the same way that goods are paid for at a shop. Everyone has something to sell.

Tramps seem to be the only exception to this general rule. Beggars almost sell themselves as human beings to arouse the pity of passers - by. But real tramps are not beggars. They have nothing to sell and require nothing from others. In seeking independence, they do not sacrifice their human dignity. A tramp may ask you for money, but he will never ask you to feel sorry for him. He has deliberately chosen to lead the life he leads and is fully aware of the consequences. He may never be sure where the next meal is coming from, but he is free from the thousands of anxieties which afflict other people. His few material possessions make it possible for him to move from place to place with ease. By having to sleep in the open, he gets far closer to the world of nature than most of us ever do. He may hunt, beg, or steal occasionally to keep himself alive; he may even, in times of real need, do a little work; but he will never sacrifice his freedom. We often speak of tramps with contempt and put them in the same class as beggars, but how many of us can honestly say that we have not felt a little envious of their simple way of life and their freedom from care?

28. Five pounds too dear

Small boats loaded with wares sped to the great liner as she was entering the harbour. Before she had anchored, the men from the boats had climbed on board and the decks were soon covered with colourful rugs from Persia, silks from India, copper coffee pots, and beautiful handmade silverware. It was difficult not to be tempted.

Many of the tourists on board had begun bargaining with the tradesmen, but I decided not to buy anything until I had disembarked. I had no sooner got off the ship than I was assailed by a man who wanted to sell me a diamond ring. I had no intention of buying one, but I could not conceal the fact that I was impressed by the size of the diamonds. Some of them were as big as marbles. The man went to great lengths to prove that the diamonds were real. As we were walking past a shop, he held a diamond firmly against the window and made a deep impression in the glass. It took me over half an hour to get rid of him.

The next man to approach me was selling expensive pens and watches. I examined one of the pens closely. It certainly looked genuine. At the base of the gold cap, the words 'made in the U.S.A.' had been neatly inscribed. The man said that the pen was worth £ 50, but as a special favour, he would let me have it for £ 30. I shook my head and held up a finger indicating that I was willing to pay a pound. Gesticulating wildly, the man acted as if he found my offer outrageous, but he eventually reduced the price to £ 10. Shrugging my shoulders, I began to walk away when, a moment later, he ran after me and thrust the pen into my hands. Though he kept throwing up his arms in despair, he readily accepted the pound I gave him. I felt especially pleased with my wonderful bargain—until I got back to the ship. No matter how hard I tried, I could not fill this beautiful pen with ink and it was only when I got off the plane that I realised that I had been tricked by the man. The pen was worthless; it was not even made of gold.

29. Funny or not

The sense of humour is mysteriously bound up with national characteristics. For instance, the French word for "funny" hardly has the same meaning as the English equivalent. If you ask a Frenchman whether the English have a sense of humour, he will probably answer, "Yes, but it's rather peculiar." You can find the same thing in other countries. Each nation has its own ideas of what is funny, and what is in bad taste.

In general, the English and the Americans do not laugh at the same things. The English, for example, do not laugh at the same kind of humour as the Americans. The things which make an Englishman laugh are not always the things which make an American laugh, and

vice versa. The fact that they laugh at different things may well make it difficult for a foreigner to understand what is really funny in either country.

Most funny stories are based on comic situations. In spite of national differences, certain funny situations have a universal appeal. No matter where you live, you would find it difficult not to laugh at, say, Charlie Chaplin's early films. However, a new type of humour, which stems from America, has recently come into fashion. It is called "sick humour". Comedians base their jokes on tragic situations like violent death or serious accidents. Many people find this sort of joke distasteful. The following example of "sick humour" will enable you to judge for yourself.

A man who had broken his right leg was taken to hospital a few weeks before Christmas. From the moment he arrived there, he kept on pestering his doctor to tell him when he would be able to go home. He dreaded having to spend Christmas in hospital. Though the doctor did his best, the patient's recovery was slow. On Christmas day, the man still had his right leg in plaster.

He spent a miserable day in bed thinking of all the fun he was missing. The following day, his mood was better. He was able to sit up in bed and look out of the window. He saw a man being taken into the hospital on a stretcher. As the man was being carried past the window, he caught sight of his neighbour's face. He was horrified to see that his neighbour had his right leg in plaster too. He called out to the man on the stretcher, "I say, what happened to you?" The man on the stretcher groaned and said, "I broke my left leg."

30. The death of a ghost

For years villagers believed that Endley Farm was haunted. The farm was owned by two brothers, Joe and Bob Cox. They employed a few farm hands, but no one was willing to work there long. Every time a worker gave up his job, he told the same story. Farm labourers said that they always woke up to find the work had been done overnight. Hay had been cut and cowsheds had been cleaned. A farm worker, who stayed up all night, claimed to have seen a figure cutting corn in the moonlight. In time, it became an accepted fact that the Cox brothers employed a conscientious ghost that did most of their work for them.

No one suspected that there might be someone else on the farm who had never been seen. This was indeed the case. A short time ago, villagers were astonished to learn that the ghost of Endley had died. Everyone went to the funeral, for the 'ghost' was none other than Eric Cox, a third brother who was supposed to have died as a young man. After the

funeral, Joe and Bob revealed a secret which they had kept for over fifty years.

Eric had been the eldest son of the family, very much older than his two brothers. He had been obliged to join the army during the Second World War. As he hated army life, he decided to desert his regiment. When he learnt that he would be sent abroad, he returned to the farm and his father hid him until the end of the war. Fearing the authorities, Eric remained in hiding after the war as well. His father told everybody that Eric had been killed in action. The only other people who knew the secret were Joe and Bob. They did not even tell their wives. When their father died, they thought it their duty to keep Eric in hiding. All these years, Eric had lived as a recluse. He used to sleep during the day and work at night, quite unaware of the fact that he had become the ghost of Endley. When he died, however, his brothers found it impossible to keep the secret any longer.

31. A Lovable Eccentric

True eccentrics never deliberately set out to draw attention to themselves. They disregard social conventions without being conscious that they are doing anything extraordinary. This invariably wins them the love and respect of others, for they add colour to the dull routine of everyday life.

Up to the time of his death, Richard Colson was one of the most notable figures in our town. He was a shrewd and wealthy business - man, but most people in the town hardly knew anything about this side of his life. He was known to us all as Dickie and his eccentricity had become legendary long before he died.

Dickie disliked snobs intensely. Though he owned a large car, he hardly ever used it, preferring always to go on foot. Even when it was raining heavily, he refused to carry an umbrella. One day, he walked into an expensive shop after having been caught in a particularly heavy shower. He wanted to buy a \\$300 watch for his wife, but he was in such a bedraggled state that an assistant refused to serve him. Dickie left the shop without a word and returned carrying a large cloth bag. As it was extremely heavy, he dumped it on the counter. The assistant asked him to leave, but Dickie paid no attention to him and requested to see the manager. Recognizing who the customer was, the manager was most apologetic and 'rushed' Dickie into the back room. Dickie took out a thick roll of \\$100 bills and started peeling them off one at a time onto the counter. On seeing this, the manager hastened to add the watch to Dickie's bill and then apologized for having been so rude before. Dickie, however, had his own way of doing things. He calmly picked up the watch, put his money back into the bag and left the shop without a word.

The following day, the manager of the shop sent his assistant to Dickie's house with a

letter. In the letter, he apologized for his rudeness and begged Dickie to come back to the shop. Dickie accepted the apology and later became a regular customer of the shop.

32. A lost ship

The salvage operation had been a complete failure. The small ship, Elkor, which had been searching the Barents Sea for weeks, was on its way home. A radio message from the mainland had been received by the ship's captain instructing him to give up the search. The captain knew that another attempt would be made later, for the sunken ship he was trying to find had been carrying a precious cargo of gold bullion.

Nevertheless, he was still unwilling to leave the area. 'I'll give it another day or two,' he said to his officers. 'We may as well start looking again. There's still a faint chance that we may find it. It's true that we've been unlucky so far, but we mustn't give up hope.'

Just as the captain was speaking, a large fish, which was almost as long as the ship itself, swam swiftly under the ship and struck it with great force. The ship shook violently and there was a loud explosion. Water flooded into the engine room and the ship sank quickly, with all hands. The captain and his officers were not the only victims. Many of the crew also lost their lives. The few survivors swam as far as they could from the sinking ship until they were picked up by a passing ship.

The Elkor's captain and his officers were taken to a nearby port. From there, they were flown back to their own country. A court of inquiry was held. The captain was blamed for the loss of the ship and for the deaths of the crew. He was found guilty and was sentenced to ten years' imprisonment. The ship's owners were also held responsible for the accident. They were ordered to pay a large sum of money in compensation.

The Elkor was a small ship, but it was carrying a very valuable cargo. It was not surprising that the search for it had been so difficult. The Barents Sea is a very large and stormy area. The ship had been missing for weeks before the Elkor started its search. It had been sailing in a remote part of the sea when it disappeared. There had been no sign of a struggle or of any damage to the ship before it sank. It was as if the ship had simply vanished into thin air.

The Elkor's search had been thorough. The ship had covered a large area of the sea. It had used the latest equipment. The captain had been experienced and determined. But in spite of all these things, the search had been a failure. It was a sad end to a long and difficult search.

33. A day to remember

We have all experienced days when everything goes wrong. A day may begin well enough, but suddenly everything seems to get out of control. What invariably happens is that a great number of things choose to go wrong at precisely the same moment. It is as if a single unimportant event set up a chain of reactions. Let us suppose that you are preparing a meal and keeping an eye on the baby at the same time. The telephone rings and this marks the prelude to an unforeseen series of catastrophes. While you are on the phone, the baby pulls the table - cloth off the table, smashing half your best crockery and cutting himself in the process. You hang up hurriedly and attend to baby, crockery, etc. Meanwhile, the meal gets burnt. As if this were not enough to reduce you to tears, your husband arrives, unexpectedly bringing three guests to dinner. Things can go wrong on a big scale, as a number of people recently discovered in Parramatta, a suburb of Sydney. During the rush hour one evening two cars collided and both drivers began to argue. The woman immediately behind the two cars happened to be a learner. She suddenly got into a panic and stopped her car. This made the driver following her brake hard. His wife was sitting beside him holding a large cake. As she was thrown forward, the cake went right through the windscreen and landed on the road. Seeing a cake flying through the air, a lorry - driver who was drawing up alongside the car, pulled up all of a sudden. The lorry was loaded with empty beer bottles and hundreds of them slid off the back of the lorry and on to the road. This led to yet another angry argument. Meanwhile, the traffic piled up behind. It took the police nearly an hour to get the traffic on the move again. In the meantime, the lorry - driver had to sweep up hundreds of broken bottles. Only two stray dogs benefited from all this confusion, for they greedily devoured the remains of the cake. It was just one of those days!

34. A Happy Discovery

Antique shops exert a peculiar fascination on a great many people. The more expensive kind of antique shop where rare objects are beautifully displayed in glass cases to keep them free from dust is usually a forbidding place. But no one has to muster up courage to enter a less pretentious antique shop. There is always hope that in its labyrinth of musty, dark, disordered rooms a real rarity will be found amongst the piles of assorted junk that litter the floors.

No one discovers a rarity by chance. A truly dedicated bargain hunter must have patience, and above all, the ability to recognize the worth of something when he sees it. To do this, he must be at least as knowledgeable as the dealer. Like a scientist bent on making a discovery, he must cherish the hope that one day he will be amply rewarded.

My old friend, Frank Halliday, is just such a person. He has often described to me how he picked up a masterpiece for a mere £5. One Saturday morning, Frank visited an antique shop in my neighbourhood. As he had never been there before, he found a great deal to interest him. The morning passed rapidly and Frank was about to leave when he noticed a large packing - case lying on the floor. The dealer told him that it had just come in, but that he could not be bothered to open it. Frank begged him to do so and the dealer reluctantly prised it open.

The contents were disappointing. Apart from an interesting - looking carved dagger, the box was full of crockery, much of it broken. Frank gently lifted the crockery out of the box and suddenly noticed a miniature painting at the bottom of the box. As its composition and line reminded him of an Italian painting he knew well, he decided to buy it. Glancing at it briefly, the dealer told him that it was worth £5. Frank could hardly conceal his excitement, for he knew that he had made a real discovery. The tiny painting proved to be an unknown masterpiece by Correggio and was worth hundreds of thousands of pounds.

35. Justice was done

The word justice is usually associated with courts of law. We might say that justice has been done when a man's innocence or guilt has been proved beyond doubt. Justice is part of the complex machinery of the law. Those who seek it, undertake an arduous journey and can never be sure that they will find it. Judges, however wise or eminent, are human and can make mistakes.

There are rare instances when justice almost ceases to be an abstract conception. Reward or punishment are meted out quite independent of human interference. At such times, justice acts like a living force. When we use a phrase like it serves him right, we are, in part, admitting that a certain set of circumstances has enabled justice to act of its own accord.

When a thief was caught on the premises of a large jewellery store one morning, the shop assistants must have found it impossible to resist the temptation to say 'it serves him right'. The shop was an old - fashioned one with many large, disused fireplaces and tall, narrow chimneys. Towards midday, a girl heard a muffled cry coming from behind one of the walls. As the cry was repeated several times, she ran to tell the manager who promptly rang up the fire brigade. The cry had certainly come from one of the chimneys, but as there were so many of them, the fire - fighters could not be certain which one it was. They located the right chimney by tapping at the walls and listening for the man's cries. After chipping through a wall which was eighteen inches thick, they found that a man had been trapped in the chimney. As it was extremely narrow, the man was unable to move, but the

firemen were eventually able to free him by cutting a huge hole in the wall. The sorry - looking, blackened figure that emerged, at once admitted that he had tried to break into the shop during the night but had got stuck in the chimney. He had been there for nearly ten hours. Justice had been done even before the man was handed over to the police.

36. A Chance in a Million

We are less credulous than we used to be. In the nineteenth century, a novelist would bring his story to a conclusion by presenting his readers with a series of coincidences - most of them wildly improbable. Readers happily accepted the fact that an obscure maidservant was really the hero's mother. A long - lost brother, who was presumed dead, was really alive all the time and wickedly plotting to bring about the hero's downfall. And so on. Modern readers would find such naive solutions totally unacceptable. Yet, in real life, circumstances do sometimes conspire to bring about coincidences which anyone but a nineteenth century novelist would find incredible.

A German taxi - driver, Franz Bussman, recently found a brother who was thought to have been killed twenty years before. While on a walking tour with his wife, he stopped to talk to a workman. After they had gone on, Mrs. Bussman commented on the workman's close resemblance to her husband and even suggested that he might be his brother. Franz poured scorn on the idea, pointing out that his brother had been killed in action during the war. Though Mrs. Bussman was fully acquainted with this story, she thought that there was a chance in a million that she might be right. A few days later, she sent a boy to the workman to ask him if his name was Hans Bussman. Needless to say, the man's name was Hans Bussman and he really was Franz's long - lost brother.

When the brothers were reunited, Hans explained how it was that he was still alive. After having been wounded towards the end of the war, he had been sent to hospital and was separated from his unit. The hospital had been bombed and Hans had made his way back into Western Germany on foot. Meanwhile, his unit was lost and all records of him had been destroyed. Hans returned to his family home, but the house had been bombed and no one in the family was alive. Assuming that his family had been killed during the air - raid, Hans settled down in a village fifty miles away where he had remained ever since.

37. The Westhaven Express

We have learnt to expect that trains will be punctual. After years of conditioning, most of us have developed an unshakable faith in railway timetables. Ships may be delayed by storms; flights may be cancelled because of bad weather, but trains must be on time. Only an exceptionally heavy snowfall might temporarily dislocate railway services. It is all too easy to blame the railway authorities when something does go wrong. The truth is that when mistakes occur, they are more likely to be ours than theirs.

After consulting my railway timetable, I noted with satisfaction that there was an express train to Westhaven. It went direct from my local station and the journey lasted a mere hour and seventeen minutes. When I boarded the train, I could not help noticing that a great many local people got on as well. At the time, this did not strike me as odd. I reflected that there must be a great many people besides myself who wished to take advantage of this excellent service. Neither was I surprised when the train stopped at Widley, a tiny station a few miles along the line. Even a mighty express train can be held up by signals. But when the train dawdled at station after station, I began to wonder. It suddenly dawned on me that this express was not roaring down the line at ninety miles an hour, but barely chugging along at thirty. One hour and seventeen minutes passed and we had not even covered half the distance. I asked a passenger if this was the Westhaven express, but he had not even heard of it.

I determined to lodge a complaint as soon as we arrived. Two hours later, I was talking angrily to the station master at Westhaven. When I told him that the train was not moving at all, he apologized for the inconvenience. Then he said something which made me think that perhaps this was not his fault after all. 'You see, sir,' he said, 'this isn't the Westhaven express. It's the slow train to Sandy Bay.' He pointed to the right. 'You should have caught the train over there two hours ago.'

38. The first calendar

Future historians will be in a unique position when they come to record the history of our own times. They will hardly know which facts to select from the great mass of evidence that steadily accumulates. What is more, they will not have to rely solely on the written word. Films, videos, CDs and CD-ROMs are just some of the bewildering amount of information they will have. They will be able, as it were, to see and hear us in action. But the historian attempting to reconstruct the distant past is always faced with a difficult task. He has to deduce what he can from the few scanty clues available. Even seemingly insignificant remains can shed interesting light on the history of early man.

Up to now, historians have assumed that calendars came into being with the advent of agriculture, for then man was faced with a real need to understand something about the seasons. Recent scientific evidence seems to indicate that this assumption is incorrect.

Historians have long been puzzled by dots, lines and symbols which have been engraved on walls, bones, and the ivory tusks of mammoths. The nomads who made these markings lived by hunting and fishing during the last Ice Age which began about 35,000 B.C. and ended about 10,000 B.C. By correlating markings made in various parts of the world, historians have been able to read this difficult code. They have found that it is connected with the passage of days and the phases of the moon. It is, in fact, a primitive type of calendar. It has long been known that the hunting scenes depicted on walls were not simply a form of artistic expression. They had a definite function, for they were as much a part of the ritual of hunting as the killing of the prey itself. This ritual was necessary to calm the gods who controlled the animals. Hunters and fishermen, in particular, were extremely superstitious. Thus, they engraved on the bones of the prey animals the signs of the moon which they had observed. The nomads who made these markings saw the moon as a major influence on their lives. They knew that it would affect the growth of plants and the migration of animals. They were convinced that it was the moon which caused the tides. They noted the phases of the moon in order to predict the times of high and low tides. They made these markings on the bones of the prey animals for two reasons. First, they wanted to record the number of kills they had made. Second, they wanted to mark the passage of days and the phases of the moon.

The ancient hunters' calendar was different from the calendars we use today. For one thing, it was not based on the movement of the sun. It was based on the movement of the moon. For another, it was not a written calendar. It was an engraved calendar. But it was a calendar just the same. It was a means of recording the passage of days and the phases of the moon. It was a way of predicting the times of high and low tides. It was a tool for hunters and fishermen. It was a form of art. It was a form of religious expression. It was a part of the ritual of hunting.

39. Nothing to worry about

The rough road across the plain soon became so bad that we tried to get Bruce to drive back to the village we had come from. Even though the road was littered with boulders and pitted with holes, Bruce was not in the least perturbed. Glancing at his map, he informed us that the next village was a mere twenty miles away. It was not that Bruce always underestimated difficulties. He simply had no sense of danger at all. No matter what the conditions were, he believed that a car should be driven as fast as it could

possibly go.

As we bumped over the dusty track, we swerved to avoid large boulders. The wheels scooped up stones which hammered ominously under the car. We felt sure that sooner or later a stone would rip a hole in our petrol tank or damage the engine. Because of this, we kept looking back, wondering if we were leaving a trail of oil and petrol behind us.

What a relief it was when the boulders suddenly disappeared, giving way to a stretch of plain where the only obstacles were clumps of bushes. But there was worse to come. Just ahead of us there was a huge fissure. In response to renewed pleadings, Bruce stopped. Though we all got out to examine the fissure, he remained in the car. We informed him that the fissure extended for fifty yards and was two feet wide and four feet deep. Even this had no effect. Bruce still drove at a terrifying speed, and soon we had left the fissure far behind. We were now in the middle of a forest which grew thicker and thicker. It was so thick that we could hardly move forward any more.

Bruce went into a low gear and drove at a terrifying speed, keeping the front wheels astride the crack as he followed its zig - zag course. We were all sweating profusely. Not for one minute did he look at the map. He was just driving. At last we could see a dim light in the distance, and soon afterwards we arrived at the village.

40. Food and Talk

Last week at a dinner - party, the hostess asked me to sit next to Mrs. Rumbold. Mrs. Rumbold was a large, unsmiling lady in a tight black dress. She did not even look up when I took my seat beside her. Her eyes were fixed on her plate and in a short time, she was busy eating. I tried to make conversation.

"A new play is coming to 'The Globe' soon," I said. "Will you be seeing it?"

"No," she answered.

"Will you be spending your holidays abroad this year?" I asked.

"No," she answered.

"Will you be staying in England?" I asked.

"No," she answered.

In despair, I asked her whether she was enjoying her dinner.

"Young man," she answered, "if you ate more and talked less, we would both enjoy our dinner!"

41. Illusions of Pastoral Peace

A gifted American psychologist has said, "Worry is a spasm of the emotion; the mind catches hold of something and will not let it go." It is useless to argue with the mind in this condition. The stronger the will, the more futile the task. One can only gently insinuate something else into its convulsive grasp. And if this something else is rightly chosen, if it really attended by the illumination of another field of interest, gradually, and often quite swiftly, the old undue grip relaxes and the process of recuperation and repair begins.

The cultivation of a hobby and new forms of interest is therefore a policy of first importance to a public man. But this is not a business that can be undertaken in a day or swiftly improvised by a mere command of the will. The growth of alternative mental interests is a long process. The seeds must be carefully chosen; they must fall on good ground; they must be sedulously tended, if the vivifying fruits are to be at hand when needed.

To be really happy and really safe, one ought to have at least two or three hobbies, and they must all be real. It is no use starting late in life to say: "I will take an interest in this or that." Such an attempt only aggravates the strain of mental effort. A man may acquire great knowledge of topics unconnected with his daily work, and yet get hardly any benefit or relief. It is no use doing what you like; you have to like what you do. Broadly speaking, human beings may be divided into three classes: those who are toiled to death, those who are worried to death, and those who are bored to death. It is no use offering the manual laborer, tired out with a hard day's work, a seat in a park or a lecture on aesthetics. It is no use inviting the politician or the business man, who has been worried about affairs of state or business all day, to attend a concert or the ballet. It is no use telling the bored, unemployed youth, "Go and play football." The right kind of spiritual food is just as necessary for one class as for another.

Those who are toiled to death are too busy to enjoy life. Those who are worried to death are too nervous to enjoy life. Those who are bored to death are too listless to enjoy life. There is no country in the world where one can not find people who would be happy to spend the rest of their lives in a village if they could. And yet, no country in the world is free from the scourge of poverty. Poverty is like a disease that is constantly spreading. It is not enough to have a good income. One must also have a good way of spending it. There are people who earn a great deal of money, but they are not happy because they do not know how to spend it. There are also people who have very little money, but they are happy because they know how to spend it.

In a world that is constantly changing, the idea of a pastoral idyll is an illusion. The idea of a simple life, free from worry and poverty, is an illusion. The idea of a life where one can

do as one pleases, without any restrictions, is an illusion. The idea of a life where one can be completely happy, without any unhappiness, is an illusion. But these illusions are not without value. They give us hope. They give us something to look forward to. They give us the strength to go on.

42. Modern Cavemen

Cave exploration, or pot-holing, as it has come to be known, is a relatively new sport. Perhaps it is the desire for solitude or the chance of making an unexpected discovery that lures people down to the depths of the earth. It is impossible to give a satisfactory explanation for a pot-holer's motives. For him, caves have the same peculiar fascination which high mountains have for the climber. They arouse instincts which can only be dimly understood.

Exploring really deep caves is not a task for the Sunday afternoon Rambler. Such undertakings require the precise planning and foresight of military operations. It can take as long as eight days to rig up rope ladders and to establish supply bases before a descent can be made into a very deep cave. Precautions of this sort are necessary, for it is impossible to foretell the exact nature of the difficulties which will confront the pot-holer. The deepest known cave in the world is the Gouffre Berger near Grenoble. It extends to a depth of 3,723 feet. This immense chasm has been formed by an underground stream which has tunnelled a course through a flaw in the rocks. The entrance to the cave is on a plateau in the Dauphine Alps. As it is only six feet across, it is barely noticeable. The cave might never have been discovered had not the entrance been spotted by the distinguished French potholer, Berger. Since its discovery, it has become a sort of pot-holers' Everest. Though a number of descents have been made, much of it still remains to be explored.

A team of pot-holers recently went down the Gouffre Berger. After entering the narrow gap on the plateau, they climbed down the steep sides of the cave until they came to a narrow corridor. They had to edge their way along this, sometimes wading across shallow streams, or swimming across deep pools. Suddenly they came to a waterfall which dropped into an underground lake at the bottom. They plunged into the lake, and after loading their gear on an inflatable rubber dinghy, let the current carry them to the other side. To their dismay, they found that the caverns were filled with water. This did not deter them, and they were determined to continue their exploration. One of the members of the team pointed out that they could not go on much longer without fresh water. This led to a search for fresh water which ended in failure. They were so thirsty that they drank a lot of the water in which they had been swimming. The water was not fresh, but it was all

they had.

Scientists have expressed their dismay at the fate of the pot - holers. Lack of fresh water and food, and exhaustion will soon make it impossible for them to continue their exploration. They hope that a rescue party will be sent as soon as possible.

43. Fully Insured

Insurance companies are normally willing to insure anything.

Insuring public or private property is a standard practice in most countries in the world.

If, however, you were holding an open air garden party or a fete it would be equally possible to insure yourself in the event of bad weather.

Needless to say, the bigger the risk an insurance company takes, the higher the premium you will have to pay.

It is not uncommon to hear that a shipping company has made a claim for the cost of salvaging a sunken ship.

But the claim made by a local authority to recover the cost of salvaging a sunken pie dish must surely be unique.

Admittedly it was an unusual pie dish, for it was eighteen feet long and six feet wide.

It had been purchased by a local authority so that an enormous pie could be baked for an annual fair.

The pie committee decided that the best way to transport the dish would be by canal, so they insured it for the trip.

Shortly after it was launched, the pie dish met with some trouble.

The vessel was stranded on a sandbank two days later in a storm.

A tugboat was sent to the ship's assistance.

Despite the fact that a tugboat was towing the pie dish, it could not prevent it from going aground again.

The local authority realized that they could not handle the situation alone, so they decided to call in a dredging company to help them out.

The dredging company sent a huge dredger which could handle the situation.

When the dredger arrived, it began to suck up the sand around the pie dish.

As it sucked up the sand, the dish became lighter and lighter.

Finally, the dish was lifted out of the sand and placed on a barge.

It was then towed to its destination.

The local authority was very pleased with the way things had been handled.

They were also very happy that they had insured the pie dish for the full value.

When they submitted their claim to the insurance company, they were surprised to find that the insurance company was also very happy to pay up.

The insurance company explained that the pie dish was a unique item and that they had no intention of disputing the claim.

After all, they had been fully insured.

44. Speed and Comfort

People traveling long distances frequently have to decide whether they would prefer to go by land, sea, or air. Hardly anyone can positively enjoy sitting in a train for more than a few hours. Train compartments soon get cramped and stuffy. It is almost impossible to take your mind off the journey. Reading is only a partial solution, for the monotonous rhythm of the wheels clicking on the rails soon lulls you to sleep. During the day, sleep comes in snatches. At night, when you really wish to go to sleep, you rarely manage to do so. If you are lucky enough to get a sleeper, you spend half the night staring at the small blue light in the ceiling, or fumbling to find your ticket for inspection. Inevitably you arrive at your destination almost exhausted. Long car journeys are even less pleasant, for it is quite impossible to read. On motorways you can, at least, travel fairly safely at high speeds, but more often than not, the greater part of the journey is spent on narrow, bumpy roads which are crowded with traffic. By comparison, trips by sea offer a great variety of civilized comforts. You can stretch your legs on the spacious decks, play games, swim, meet interesting people and enjoy good food---always assuming, of course, that the sea is calm. If it is not, and you are likely to get seasick, no form of transport could be worse. Even if you travel in ideal weather, sea journeys take a long time. Relatively few people are prepared to sacrifice up to a third of their holidays for the pleasure of traveling on a ship. Aeroplanes have the reputation of being dangerous and even hardened travellers are intimidated by them. They also have the disadvantage of being an expensive form of transport. But nothing can match them for speed and comfort. Traveling at a height of 30,000 feet, far above the clouds, and at over 500 miles an hour is an exhilarating experience. You do not have to devise ways of taking your mind off the journey, for an aeroplane gets you to your destination rapidly. For a few hours, you settle back in a deep armchair to enjoy the flight. The real escapist can watch a free film show

and sip champagne on some services. But even when such refinements are not available, there is plenty to keep you occupied. An aeroplane offers you an unusual and breathtaking view of the world. You soar effortlessly over high mountains and deep valleys. You really see the shape of the land. If the landscape is hidden from view, you can enjoy the extraordinary sight of unbroken cloud plains that stretch out for miles before you, while the sun shines brilliantly in a clear sky. The journey is so smooth that there is nothing to prevent you from reading or sleeping. However you decide to spend your time, one thing is certain: you will arrive at your destination fresh and uncrumpled. You will not have to spend the next few days recovering from a long and arduous journey.

45. The power of the press

In democratic countries any efforts to restrict the freedom of the press are rightly condemned. However, this freedom can easily be abused. Stories about people often attract far more public attention than political events. Though we may enjoy reading about the lives of others, it is extremely doubtful whether we would equally enjoy reading about ourselves. Acting on the contention that facts are sacred, reporters can cause untold suffering to individuals by publishing details about their private lives. Newspapers exert such tremendous influence that they can not only bring about major changes to the lives of ordinary people but can even overthrow a government.

The story of a poor family that acquired fame and fortune overnight, dramatically illustrates the power of the press. The family lived in Aberdeen, a small town of 23,000 inhabitants in South Dakota. As the parents had five children, life was a perpetual struggle against poverty. They were expecting their sixth child and were faced with even more pressing economic problems. If they had only had one more child, the fact would have passed unnoticed. They would have continued to struggle against economic odds and would have lived in obscurity.

But they suddenly became the parents of quintuplets, four girls and a boy, an event which radically changed their lives. The day after the birth of the five children, an aeroplane arrived in Aberdeen bringing sixty reporters and photographers. The news was of national importance, for the couple had become the parents of the only quintuplets in America.

The rise to fame was swift. Television cameras and newspapers carried the news to everyone in the country. Newspapers and magazines offered the family huge sums for the exclusive rights to publish stories and photographs. Gifts poured in not only from unknown people, but from baby - food manufacturers who wished to advertise their products. The old farmhouse the family lived in was to be replaced by a new \$100,000 home. Reporters kept pressing for interviews so lawyers had to be employed to act as

spokes - men for the family at press conferences.

While the five babies were still quietly sleeping in oxygen tents in a hospital nursery, their parents were paying the price for fame. It would never again be possible for them to lead normal lives. They had become the victims of commercialization, for their names had acquired a market value. Instead of being five new family members, these children had immediately become a commodity.

46. Do it yourself

So great is our passion for doing things for ourselves, that we are becoming increasingly less dependent on specialized labour. No one can plead ignorance of a subject any longer, for there are countless do - it - yourself publications. Armed with the right tools and materials, newly - weds gaily embark on the task of decorating their own homes. Men, particularly, spend hours of their leisure time installing their own fireplaces, laying out their own gardens; building garages and making furniture. Some really keen enthusiasts go so far as to build their own computers. Shops cater for the do - it - yourself craze not only by running special advisory services for novices, but by offering consumers bits and pieces which they can assemble at home. Such things provide an excellent outlet for pent - up creative energy, but unfortunately not all of us are born handymen.

Some wives tend to believe that their husbands are infinitely resourceful and can fix anything. Even men who can hardly drive a nail in straight are supposed to be born electricians, carpenters, plumbers and mechanics. When lights fuse, furniture gets rickety, pipes get clogged, or vacuum cleaners fail to operate, some women assume that their husbands will somehow put things right. The worst thing about the do - it - yourself game is that sometimes even men live under the delusion that they can do anything, even when they have repeatedly been proved wrong. It is a question of pride as much as anything else.

Last spring my wife suggested that I call in a man to look at our lawn - mower. It had broken down the previous summer, and though I promised to repair it, I had never got round to it. I would not hear of the suggestion and said that I would fix it myself. One Saturday afternoon, I hauled the machine into the garden and had a close look at it. As far as I could see, it only needed a minor adjustment: a turn of a screw here, a little tightening up there, a drop of oil and it would be as good as new. Inevitably the repair job was not quite so simple. The mower firmly refused to mow, so I decided to dismantle it. The garden was soon littered with chunks of metal which had once made up a lawn - mower. But I was extremely pleased with myself. I had traced the cause of the trouble. One of the links in the chain that drives the wheels had snapped.

After buying a new chain I was faced with the insurmountable task of putting the confusing jigsaw puzzle together again. I was not surprised to find that the machine still refused to work after I had reassembled it, for the simple reason that I was left with several curiously shaped bits of metal which did not seem to fit anywhere. I gave up in despair. The weeks passed and the grass grew. When my wife nagged me to do something about it, I told her that either I would have to buy a new mower or let the grass grow. Needless to say, our garden is still a mess.

47. Too high a price

Pollution is the price we pay for an overpopulated, over industrialized planet. When you come to think about it, there are only four ways you can deal with rubbish: dump it, burn it, turn it into something you can use again, attempt to produce less of it. We keep trying all four methods, but the sheer volume of rubbish we produce worldwide threatens to overwhelm us. Rubbish, however, is only part of the problem of polluting our planet. The need to produce ever - increasing quantities of cheap food leads to a different kind of pollution. Industrialized farming methods produce cheap meat products: beef, pork and chicken. The use of pesticides and fertilizers produces cheap grain and vegetables. The price we pay for cheap food may be already too high: Mad Cow Disease (BSE) in cattle, salmonella in chicken and eggs, and listeria in dairy products. And if you think you'll abandon meat and become a vegetarian, you have the choice of very expensive organically - grown vegetables or a steady diet of pesticides every time you think you're eating fresh salads and vegetables, or just having an innocent glass of water! However, there is an even more insidious kind of pollution that particularly affects urban areas and invades our daily lives, and that is noise. Burglar alarms going off at any time of the day or night serve only to annoy passers - by and actually assist burglars to burgle. Car alarms constantly scream at us in the street and are a source of profound irritation. A recent survey of the effects of noise revealed (surprisingly?) that dogs barking incessantly in the night rated the highest form of noise pollution on a scale ranging from 1 to 7. The survey revealed a large number of sources of noise that we really dislike: lawn mowers, transistor radios, motorcycles, etc. New technology has also made its own contribution to noise. A lot of people object to mobile phones, especially when they are used in public places like restaurants or on public transport. Loud conversations on mobile phones invade our thoughts or interrupt the pleasure of meeting friends for a quiet chat. The noise pollution survey revealed a rather surprising and possibly amusing old - fashioned source of noise. It seems we are at our noisiest when we are asleep! The rattling noise of the alarm clock at the bedside wakes us up. What an irritating way to start the day! It doesn't have to be this

way. There are laws in most cities to stop factories emitting black smoke into the atmosphere, and there are also laws which force people to adopt anti - pollution measures, but these laws are not always rigidly enforced. It is cheaper for companies to break the laws and pay the fines than to buy the expensive equipment that will reduce the pollution. It is also cheaper for people to continue to throw rubbish away than to spend time and money on recycling. Noise pollution is at its worst in cities. It can make people ill, or drive them mad. It is a problem that we cannot afford to ignore.

48. The Silent Village

In this much - travelled world, there are still thousands of places which are inaccessible to tourists. We always assume that villagers in remote places are friendly and hospitable. But people who are cut off not only from foreign tourists, but even from their own countrymen can be hostile to travellers. Visits to really remote villages are seldom enjoyable - as my wife and I discovered during a tour through the Balkans.

We had spent several days in a small town and visited a number of old churches in the vicinity. These attracted many visitors, for they were not only of great architectural interest, but contained a large number of beautifully preserved frescoes as well. On the day before our departure, several bus loads of tourists descended on the town. This was more than we could bear, so we decided to spend our last day exploring the countryside. Taking a path which led out of the town, we crossed a few fields until we came to a dense wood. We expected the path to end abruptly, but we found that it traced its way through the trees. We tramped through the wood for over two hours until we arrived at a deep stream. We could see that the path continued on the other side, but we had no idea how we could get across the stream. Suddenly my wife spotted a boat moored to the bank. In it there was a boatman fast asleep. We gently woke him up and asked him to ferry us across the stream. The boatman got up, stretched himself and made ready to set off. He was a huge man, well over six feet tall, and broad in proportion, and his muscles bulged out of his shirt sleeves as he rowed. The boat glided smoothly across the lake and we got out on the opposite bank. We were about to walk away when the boatman called out to us. He said something in his local dialect which we could not understand, but he motioned to us to wait. He then went back to the boat and brought out a large tin box. He placed it on the ground in front of us and opened it. Inside were dozens of beautifully carved wooden animals. He had carved them himself, and they were all as different as the villagers whom we had left behind. The boatman wanted an exorbitant amount of money for them, but we had no choice but to pay up. After all, we had no idea how we could get back without his boat. We made our way back to the town as quickly as possible, but we

were not in time to catch the bus for our next destination. So we had to hire a car and drive to the airport. The journey was long and tiring, but we were glad to be away from the Silent Village.

49. The Ideal Servant

It is a good thing my aunt Harriet died years ago. If she were alive today she would not be able to air her views on her favourite topic of conversation: domestic servants. Aunt Harriet lived in that leisurely age when servants were employed to do housework. She had a huge, rambling country house called 'The Gables'. She was sentimentally attached to this house, for even though it was far too big for her needs, she persisted in living there long after her husband's death. Before she grew old, Aunt Harriet used to entertain lavishly. I often visited The Gables when I was a boy. No matter how many guests were present, the great house was always immaculate. The parquet floors shone like mirrors; highly polished silver was displayed in gleaming glass cabinets; even my uncle's huge collection of books was kept miraculously free from dust. Aunt Harriet presided over an invisible army of servants that continuously scrubbed, cleaned, and polished. She always referred to them as 'the shifting population', for they came and went with such frequency that I never even got a chance to learn their names. Though my aunt pursued what was, in those days, an enlightened policy, in that she never allowed her domestic staff to work more than eight hours a day, she was extremely difficult to please. While she always decried the fickleness of human nature, she carried on an unrelenting search for the ideal servant to the end of her days, even after she had been seriously weakened by a stroke. Even when she was unable to speak, still her eyes, full of pain and suffering, expressed her unspoken thoughts. Her last message to me consisted of a single word: 'Servants'.

50. New Year Resolutions

The New Year is a time for resolutions. Mentally, at least, most of us could compile formidable lists of 'dos' and 'don'ts'. The same old favourites recur year in year out with monotonous regularity. We resolve to get up earlier each morning, eat less, find more time to play with the children, do a thousand and one jobs about the house, be nice to people we don't like, drive carefully, and take the dog for a walk every day. Past experience has taught us that certain accomplishments are beyond attainment. If we remain inveterate smokers, it is only because we have so often experienced the frustration that results from failure. Most of us fail in our efforts at self - improvement because our

schemes are too ambitious and we never have time to carry them out. We also make the fundamental error of announcing our resolutions to everybody so that we look even more foolish when we slip back into our bad old ways. Aware of these pitfalls, this year I attempted to keep my resolutions to myself. I limited myself to two modest ambitions: to do physical exercises every morning and to read more of an evening. An all - night party on New Year's Eve provided me with a good excuse for not carrying out either of these new resolutions on the first day of the New Year, but on the second, I applied myself assiduously to the task.

The daily exercises lasted only eleven minutes and I proposed to do them early in the morning before anyone had got up. The self - discipline required to drag myself out of bed eleven minutes earlier than usual was considerable. Nevertheless, I managed to creep down into the living - room for two days before anyone found me out. After jumping about on the carpet and twisting the human frame into uncomfortable positions, I sat down at the breakfast table in an exhausted state. It was this that betrayed me. My wife was sitting opposite me, looking rather glum.

'You don't look very well,' she said. 'Is something wrong?'

'I've been doing my exercises,' I said.

'What exercises?' she asked in surprise.

'Jumping about on the carpet and twisting the human frame into uncomfortable positions,' I replied.

'Good heavens!' she exclaimed. 'Why on earth are you doing that?'

'Well, I've made a resolution to do physical exercises every morning,' I explained.

'But you don't look as if you've been doing physical exercises,' she said.

'I haven't finished yet,' I said. 'I've only been doing them for two days.'

'You're making a fool of yourself,' she said. 'You can't expect to improve your physical condition in two days. You need at least a couple of weeks.'

'I know,' I said. 'But I'm determined to carry out my resolution.'

'I'm sure you are,' she said. 'But you're still making a fool of yourself.'

I decided to give up the exercises, because it was clear that my wife was right. I had been making a fool of myself. It was not so much my appearance that betrayed me as my lack of energy. I realized that if I continued to do the exercises, I would be making a fool of myself even more. So I abandoned the idea of physical exercises and concentrated on my second resolution: reading more of an evening. This was easier said than done, because I soon discovered that I had not got the necessary books. I had been thinking about buying some new books for a long time, but I had always postponed the purchase. Now that I

had made a resolution to read more, I needed to buy some books. I went to the local bookstore, but I could not find any books that I really wanted to buy. I was disappointed, but I did not give up. I went to another bookstore, and this time I found some books that I liked. I bought them and took them home. I was pleased with my purchase, but I knew that I still had a long way to go before I could say that I had carried out my resolution. I needed to find time to read the books, and I needed to make sure that I did not slip back into my bad old ways of not reading enough.

51. Predicting the future

Predicting the future is notoriously difficult. Who could have imagined, in the mid 1970s, for example, that by the end of the 20th century, computers would be as common in people's homes as TV sets? In the 1970s, computers were common enough, but only in big business, government departments, and large organizations. These were the so - called mainframe machines. Mainframe computers were very large indeed, often occupying whole air - conditioned rooms, employing full - time technicians and run on specially - written software. Though these large machines still exist, many of their functions have been taken over by small powerful personal computers, commonly known as PCs.

No one could have foreseen, in those days, the rise of these machines called PCs, in which people could type in commands instead of punching holes in cards. It has become clear that the Internet - the computers - network is one of the most powerful tools for the 21st century. School children who know how to use the Internet will be at a great advantage over those who don't. There is no doubt that all this new technology is changing the way we work and offering many other ways of working. We no longer have to work at the same time, at the same place every day. People can telecommute in their pajamas if they like. A recent survey in the United States showed that 80% of all companies interviewed were either already using or planning to use the Internet in their business.

One of the greatest benefits of Internet shopping is that it is open seven days a week, 24 hours a day. Shoppers no longer have to queue up in stores during the rush - hour. This is a great convenience for those who are too busy to go to the stores during regular business hours. The Internet also makes it easier for companies to keep in touch with their customers and for people to keep in touch with each other. Companies can e - mail newsletters to their customers. And families and friends can send e - mails to each other instead of writing letters or making phone calls.

Another big advantage of the Internet is the amount of information that is available. There are sites on the Internet that list the full text of books. Some sites allow you to

download entire books. Other sites offer encyclopedias, dictionaries, and other reference materials. You can also find newspapers, magazines, and other periodicals on the Internet. And, of course, there are millions of web pages with all kinds of information on them.

Predicting the future of the Internet is also difficult. Some experts believe that the Internet will continue to grow and expand. They think that more and more people will use the Internet, and that it will become even more powerful. Others believe that the Internet will become overcrowded and that its growth will slow down. There are also concerns about security. How can we be sure that our e - mail messages are private? How can we be sure that the information we download from the Internet is accurate? These are all questions that need to be answered as the Internet continues to grow.

But one thing is certain: the Internet has changed our lives, and it will continue to change our lives in the future.

52. Mud is Mud

My cousin, Harry, keeps a large curiously-shaped bottle on permanent display in his study. Despite the fact that the bottle is tinted a delicate shade of green, an observant visitor would soon notice that it is filled with what looks like a thick, grayish substance.

If you were to ask Harry what was in the bottle, he would tell you that it contained perfumed mud. If you expressed doubt or surprise, he would immediately invite you to smell it and then to rub some into your skin. This brief experiment would dispel any further doubts you might have. The bottle really does contain perfumed mud.

How Harry came into the possession of this outlandish stuff makes an interesting story which he is fond of relating. Furthermore, the acquisition of this bottle cured him of a bad habit he had been developing for years.

Harry used to consider it a great joke to go into expensive cosmetic shops and make outrageous requests for goods that do not exist. He would invent fanciful names on the spot. On entering a shop, he would ask for a new perfume called 'Scented Shadow' or for 'insoluble bath cubes'. If a shop assistant told him she had not heard of it, he would pretend to be considerably put out. He loved to be told that one of his imaginary products was temporarily out of stock and he would faithfully promise to call again at some future date, but of course he never did. How Harry managed to keep a straight face during these performances is quite beyond me.

Harry does not need to be prompted to explain how he bought his precious bottle of mud. One day, while he was on holiday, he visited a temple. He noticed that there was an unusual amount of activity going on around an apparently derelict building. Asking

around, he discovered that a monk had been living there for years. The monk had been violating the law, repeatedly begging for alms in the town. The townspeople were not very happy about this, but they did not want to offend the monk. They just wished he would go away.

Finally, the townspeople could not stand it any longer and decided to do something about it. They called in a local builder. The builder inspected the building and said that he would be able to make it habitable with a bit of repair work. The townspeople were very happy to hear this and immediately set about collecting money from the public. The builder said that he would start work as soon as he received the money.

The monk, who had heard about this, was not very happy. He did not want to lose his home. He thought of a plan. He went to a nearby cosmetics factory and bought a large bottle of perfumed mud. He took it back to the temple and poured it all over the building. When the townspeople and the builder arrived, they were horrified. The building was covered in a thick layer of grayish mud. The builder said that he could not possibly repair the building now. The townspeople were angry with the monk, but they did not want to get their hands dirty trying to clean it up. They just left the monk alone in his muddy building.

Harry, who had witnessed all this, was very amused. He thought that the monk was very clever. He decided to buy the bottle of mud from the monk. The monk was happy to sell it to him. Harry took the bottle home and put it on permanent display in his study.

53. In the Public Interest

The Scandinavian countries are much admired all over the world for their enlightened social policies. Sweden has evolved an excellent system for protecting the individual citizen from high - handed or incompetent public officers. The system has worked so well, that it has been adopted in other countries too.

The Swedes were the first to recognize that public official like civil servants, police officers, health inspectors or tax - collectors can make mistakes or act over - zealously in the belief that they are serving the public. As long ago as 1809, the Swedish Parliament introduced a scheme to safeguard the interest of the individual. A parliamentary committee representing all political parties appoints a person who is suitably qualified to investigate private grievances against the State. The official title of the person is 'Justiteombudsman', but the Swedes commonly refer to him as the 'J.O.' or 'Ombudsman'.

The Ombudsman is not subject to political pressure. He investigates complaints large and small that come to him from all levels of society. As complaints must be made in writing,

the Ombudsman receives an average of 1,200 letters a year. He has eight lawyer assistants to help him and he examines every single letter in detail. There is nothing secretive about the Ombudsman's work, for his correspondence is open to public inspection. If a citizen's complaint is justified, the Ombudsman will act on his behalf. The action he takes varies according to the nature of the complaint. He may gently reprimand an official or even suggest to parliament that a law be altered. The following case is a typical example of the Ombudsman's work.

A foreigner living in a Swedish village wrote to the Ombudsman complaining that he had been ill - treated by the police, simply because he was a foreigner. The Ombudsman immediately wrote to the Chief of Police in the district asking him to send a record of the case. There was nothing in the record to show that the foreigner's complaints were justified. The Ombudsman nevertheless decided to carry out an investigation, for he had received similar complaints from other foreigners in the area. He sent a form to the police chief asking him to make a list of all the foreign residents in the district. The police chief did so and sent the list to the Ombudsman. The Ombudsman then sent a letter to each of the foreigners asking them to describe their experiences with the police. In reply, he received a number of letters from the foreigners which told of the same kind of ill - treatment by the police. These letters enabled the Ombudsman to prove that the police had acted unjustly. He reprimanded the police chief in writing and demanded that he send a written apology to the foreigner. The police chief complied and the foreigner was satisfied.

The Ombudsman's job is not an easy one. He often has to work long hours, and he has to be able to stand up to political pressure. But he is highly respected for his integrity and his impartiality.

54. Instinct or Cleverness

We have been brought up to fear insects. We regard them as unnecessary creatures that do more harm than good. Man continually wages war on them, for they contaminate his food, carry diseases, or devour his crops. They sting or bite without provocation; they fly uninvited into our rooms on summer nights, or beat against our lighted windows.

We live in dread not only of unpleasant insects like spiders or wasps, but of quite harmless one like moths. Reading about them increases our understanding without dispelling our fears. Knowing that the industrious ant lives in a highly organized society does nothing to prevent us from being filled with revulsion when we find hordes of them crawling over a carefully prepared picnic lunch.

No matter how much we like honey, or how much we have read about the uncanny sense of direction which bees possess, we have a horror of being stung. Most of our fears are unreasonable, but they are impossible to erase. At the same time, however, insects are strangely fascinating. We enjoy reading about them, especially when we find that, like the praying mantis, they lead perfectly horrible lives. We enjoy staring at them, entranced as they go about their business, unaware (we hope) of our presence. Who has not stood in awe at the sight of a spider pouncing on a fly, or a column of ants triumphantly bearing home an enormous dead beetle?

Last summer I spent days in the garden watching thousands of ants crawling up the trunk of my prize peach tree. The tree has grown against a warm wall on a sheltered side of the house. I am especially proud of it, not only because it has survived several severe winters, but because it occasionally produces luscious peaches. During the summer, I noticed that the leaves of the tree were beginning to wither. Clusters of tiny insects called aphids were to be found on the underside of the leaves. They were sucking sap from the underside of the leaves of my prize peach tree. I immediately fetched a can of insecticide and sprayed the underside of the leaves thoroughly. I repeated the spraying operation several times before I felt satisfied that I had got rid of all the aphids. For two more weeks, I watched the tree carefully. It seemed that the aphids were gone and the tree was beginning to thrive again. Then, without warning, a large number of ants began to climb the tree. They were making their way up the trunk in long, thin lines. As soon as they reached the underside of the leaves, they set to work on the aphids. They were carrying the aphids' eggs; they were licking the aphids; they were taking care of the aphids all in return for a little sap which the aphids secrete. I realized that I had been wrong in thinking that the ants were simply thieves. They were in fact the protectors of the aphids. The aphids were supplying the ants with food, and the ants were protecting the aphids from the insecticide spray. It is not always easy to distinguish between things that are beneficial and things that are harmful. It is often necessary to make a distinction between instinct and cleverness.

55. From the Earth: Greetings

Recent developments in astronomy have made it possible to detect planets in our own Milky Way and in other galaxies. This is a major achievement because, in relative terms, planets are very small and do not emit light. Finding planets is proving hard enough, but finding life on them will prove infinitely more difficult. The first question to answer is whether a planet can actually support life. In our own solar system, for example, Venus is far too hot and Mars is far too cold to support life. Only the Earth provides ideal

conditions, and even here it has taken more than four billion years for plant and animal life to evolve.

Whether a planet can support life depends on the size and brightness of its star, that is its 'sun'. Imagine a star up to twenty times larger, brighter and hotter than our own sun. A planet would have to be a very long way from it to be capable of supporting life. On the other hand, if the star were small, the life - supporting planet would have to have a close orbit round it and also provide the perfect conditions for water: not too hot and not too cold, as otherwise water would turn to vapour or ice.

Secondly, we may wonder whether there is life on other planets. At present we can only detect life - forms that are based on carbon. Consequently, a search for non - carbon - based life forms may prove to be a fruitless search. However, it is probably a mistake to assume that other life - forms would be similar to our own. They might not need water or oxygen, or even light, as we do. Instead, they might have developed other ways of growing, moving or reproducing.

Finally, we may ask whether life on other planets would be friendly or hostile to us. The answer to this question depends on whether we consider them as potential friends or foes. If we consider them as friends, we will be more likely to welcome them. If we consider them as foes, we will be more likely to fear them. However, given the vastness of the universe, it is more likely that we will never know the answer to this question.

56. Our neighbour, the river

The river which forms the eastern boundary of our farm has always played an important part in our lives. Without it we could not make a living. There is only enough spring water to supply the needs of the house, so we have to pump from the river for farm use. We tell the river all our secrets. We know instinctively, just as beekeepers with their bees, that misfortune might overtake us if the important events of our lives were not related to it.

Of course, the great thing is not to allow any dogmatic to creep in, not to become narrow and intolerant. And it is the same with political opinions. We all know people who are so addicted to their particular variety of snobbery that they limit their intercourse to people of their own kind, and are very surprised and even hurt if one day they find that their teenage son or daughter has married outside their own class or group. But on the whole, we all have a very wide common ground of agreement on which we can talk without any feeling of restraint or self - consciousness. We all know that if we overfish, the fish in the river will soon be exhausted, and so we have an agreement not to fish in the river for more than a certain number of fish each season. We also know that if we do not take

good care of the river, the fish will die, and so we have an agreement to keep the river clean.

There is also the question of security. We all know that if we are not on our guard, some day we will be invaded by our neighbours on the other side of the river. So we keep a watchful eye on them, and at the same time we make sure that they know that we are watching them. But on the whole, we live in peace with them. We are all neighbours, after all.

Our relationship with the river is like that of the ancient Greeks with their gods. We have sacrificed a lot to it, and we have also received a lot from it. It is a very important part of our lives.

57. Back in the old country

I stopped to let the car cool off and to study the map. I had expected to be near my objective by now, but everything still seemed alien to me. I was only five when my father had taken me abroad, and that was eighteen years ago. When my mother had died after a tragic accident, he did not quickly recover from the shock and loneliness. Everything around him was full of her presence, continually reopening the wound. So he decided to emigrate. In the new country he became absorbed in making a new life for the two of us, so that he gradually ceased to grieve. He did not marry again and I was brought up without a woman's care; but I lacked for nothing, for he was both father and mother to me. He always meant to go back one day, but not to stay. His roots and mine had become too firmly embedded in the new land. But he wanted to see the old folk again and to visit my mother's grave. He became mortally ill a few months before we had planned to go and, when he knew that he was dying, he made me promise to go on my own. I hired a car the day after landing and bought a comprehensive book of maps, which I found most helpful on the cross-country journey, but which I did not think I should need on the last stage. It was not that I actually remembered anything at all. But my father had described over and over again what we should see at every milestone, after leaving the nearest town, so that I was positive I should recognize it as familiar territory. Well, I had been wrong, for I was now lost. I looked at the map and then at the milometer. I had come ten miles since leaving the town, and at this point, according to my father, I should be looking at farms and cottages in a valley, with the spire of the church of our village showing in the far distance. I could see no valley, no farms, no cottages and no church spire - only a lake. I decided that I must have taken a wrong turning somewhere. So I drove back to the town and began to retrace my steps, taking the routes I had not taken before. It was a slow process, full of frustrations and regular disappointments. Just when I was beginning to

despair, I came upon a signpost. And it was only as I was studying it that I realized I had been looking at it from the wrong angle all the time. There was my village, right where my father had said it would be. I drove on for a few miles and then I saw it. My father had described it to me so often that I recognized it immediately - my mother's old home. Then I turned a corner and, as I did so, I realized that I had been deceived by an optical illusion. I had been following a man who was two hundred yards ahead of me and who was also driving slowly. As he turned a corner, I assumed that he must be making for the same destination as myself. I followed him for a long time, but at last I lost him in the darkness. I looked at my watch. It was past midnight. I was very tired and also very hungry by this time, but there was still no sign of the village. I was beginning to wonder if I had made a mistake. Just then I saw a faint light in the distance. I drove towards it, hoping that it was a sign of some sort of habitation. It was a small house, and I could see a man working in the garden. I got out of the car and walked towards him. He stopped his work and looked at me. "You're lost, aren't you?" he said. "Yes," I replied. "I'm looking for my mother's old home." "Your mother's old home?" he said. "There are no houses here." "But it must be here," I said. "My father described it to me so often." "Your father?" he said. "Who was your father?" "His name was Henry," I said. "Henry who?" he asked. "Henry Twycross," I said. "Oh," he said. "I knew him. He used to live here. But that was a long time ago. There's been a lot of change since then." "But where is my mother's old home?" I asked. "It's gone," he said. "It was knocked down years ago." "But why?" I asked. "Because it was in the way of progress," he said. "There was a new road being built and it had to be removed." "So what am I to do?" I asked. "You can stay here if you like," he said. "I have a spare room." "Thank you," I said. "But I think I'll go on." "Where to?" he asked. "I don't know," I said. "I just want to see the old country." "Well," he said. "Good luck." I got back into the car and drove off. I was very sad. I had come all this way to find my mother's old home, but it was gone. I had been deceived by my father's description and by my own memories. I was lost again, not only in the physical sense but also in the emotional sense. I drove on for a while, but I was not really interested in where I was going. I was just thinking about my father and my mother and the old days. Then I saw a signpost. It said "To the old country". I followed it. I don't know where it led me, but I followed it. I was still lost, but I was following the signpost to the old country.

58. A Spot of Bother

The old lady was glad to be back at the block of flats where she lived. Her shopping had tired her and her basket had grown heavier with every step of the way home. In the lift her thoughts were on lunch and a good rest; but when she got out at her own floor, both were forgotten in her sudden discovery that her front door was open. She was thinking that she must reprimand her daily maid the next morning for such a monstrous piece of negligence, when she remembered that she had gone shopping after the maid had left and she knew that she had turned both keys in their locks. She walked slowly into the hall and at once noticed that all the room doors were open, yet following her regular practice she had shut them before going out. Looking into the drawing room, she saw a scene of confusion over by her writing desk. It was as clear as daylight then that burglars had forced an entry during her absence. Her first impulse was to go round all the rooms looking for the thieves, but then she decided that at her age it might be more prudent to have someone with her, so she went to fetch the porter from his basement. By this time her legs were beginning to tremble, so she sat down and accepted a cup of very strong tea, while he telephoned the police. Then, her composure regained, she was ready to set off with the porter's assistance to search for any intruders who might still be lurking in her flat.

They went through the rooms, being careful to touch nothing, as they did not want to hinder the police in their search for fingerprints. The chaos was inconceivable. She had lived in the flat for thirty years and was a veritable magpie at hoarding; and it seemed as though everything she possessed had been tossed out and turned over and over. At least sorting out the things she should have discarded years ago was now being made easier for her. Then a police inspector arrived with a constable and she told them of her discovery of the ransacked flat. The inspector began to look for fingerprints, while the constable checked that the front door locks had not been forced, thereby proving that the burglars had either used skeleton keys or entered over the balcony. There was no trace of fingerprints, but the inspector found a dirty red bundle that contained jewellery which the old lady said was not hers. So their entry into this flat was apparently not the burglars' first job that day and they must have been disturbed. The inspector then asked the old lady to try to check what was missing by the next day and advised her not to stay alone in the flat for a few nights. The old lady thought he was a fussy old fool at first, for to her, nothing seemed to be missing at all. But on entering her bedroom, she was shocked to find that the bed had been stripped of its coverings. At that moment she realized that she had not seen her cat for a long time. She was certain that the burglars had taken it when they had ransacked her flat. Then she began to sob inconsolably. Half an hour later, still sobbing, she telephoned the police and said that she had been wrong to call them fussy old fools. Because, she said, when she went to feed her cat just now she had found it

stuffed in the wardrobe in a dirty red bundle.

59. Collecting

People tend to amass possessions, sometimes without being aware of doing so. Indeed they can have a delightful surprise when they find something useful which they did not know they owned. Those who never have to change house become indiscriminate collectors of what can only be described as clutter. They leave unwanted objects in drawers, cupboards and attics for years, in the belief that they may one day need just those very things. As they grow old, people also accumulate belongings for two other reasons, lack of physical and mental energy, both of which are essential in turning out and throwing away, and sentiment. Things owned for a long time are full of associations with the past, perhaps with relatives who are dead, and so they gradually acquire a value beyond their true worth.

Some things are collected deliberately in the home in an attempt to avoid waste. Among these I would list string and brown paper, kept by thrifty people when a parcel has been opened, to save buying these two requisites. Collecting small items can easily become a mania. I know someone who always cuts sketches out from newspapers of model clothes that she would like to buy if she had the money. As she is not rich, the chances that she will ever be able to afford such purchases are remote; but she is never sufficiently strong-minded to be able to stop the practice. It is a harmless habit, but it litters up her desk to such an extent that every time she opens it, loose bits of paper fall out in every direction.

Collecting as a serious hobby is quite different and has many advantages. It provides relaxation for leisure hours, as just looking at one's treasures is always a joy. One does not have to go outside for amusement, since the collection is housed at home. Whatever it consists of, stamps, records, first editions of books, china, glass, antique furniture, pictures, model cars, stuffed animals, toy animals, there is always something to do in connection with it, from finding the right place for the latest addition, to verifying facts in reference books. This hobby educates one not only in the chosen subject, but also in general matters which have some bearing on it. There are also other benefits. One's friends and relatives, in their turn, may feel obliged to present the collector with gifts related to his collection. And these gifts need not be expensive. A young relative of mine, who is studying for a postgraduate degree in music, recently sent me a present of a book on the history of the piano. It was a very welcome gift as I have an interest in music and am also collecting books related to music.

Collectors may get a feeling of satisfaction from the fact that they have found something rare. But there is also the possibility that they may become obsessed with their hobby and

spend all their time and money on it. This can lead to problems. For example, a collector who has a passion for antique furniture may find it difficult to resist the temptation to buy a very expensive piece, even if he does not have the money to pay for it. Or a stamp collector may become so obsessed with his stamps that he neglects his family and friends. In general, however, the advantages of collecting as a hobby far outweigh the disadvantages.

60. Too early and too late

Punctuality is a necessary habit in all public affairs in civilized society. Without it, nothing could ever be brought to a conclusion; everything would be in a state of chaos. Only in a sparsely - populated rural community is it possible to disregard it. In ordinary living, there can be some tolerance of unpunctuality. The intellectual, who is working on some abstruse problem, has everything coordinated and organized for the matter in hand. He is therefore forgiven, if late for a dinner party. But people are often reproached for unpunctuality when their only fault is cutting things fine. It is hard for energetic, quick - minded people to waste time, so they are often tempted to finish a job before setting out to keep an appointment. If no accidents occur on the way, like punctured tyres, diversions of traffic, sudden descent of fog, they will be on time. They are often more industrious, useful citizens than those who are never late. The over - punctual can be as much a trial to others as the unpunctual. The guest who arrives half an hour too soon is the greatest nuisance. Some friends of my family had this irritating habit. The only thing to do was ask them to come half an hour later than the other guests. Then they arrived just when we wanted them.

If you are catching a train, it is always better to be comfortably early than even a fraction of a minute too late. Although being early may mean wasting a little time, this will be less than if you miss the train and have to wait an hour or more for the next one; and you avoid the frustration of arriving at the very moment when the train is drawing out of the station and being unable to get on it. An even harder situation is to be on the platform in good time for a train and still to see it go off without you. Such an experience befell a certain young girl the first time she was travelling alone.

She entered the station twenty minutes before the train was due, since her parents had impressed upon her that it would be unforgivable to miss it and cause the friends with whom she was going to stay to make two journeys to meet her. She gave her luggage to a porter and showed him her ticket. To her horror he said that she was two hours too early. She felt in her handbag for the piece of paper on which her father had written down all the details of the journey and gave it to the porter. He agreed that a train did come

into the station at the time on the paper, but he said that it only stopped there to take on water, not passengers. So she sat down to wait for the train which was coming in four hours' time. She had been told that her train was the one which left at five o'clock. When she arrived at the station, she found that her train had already left. She had missed it by a few minutes. This was the first time that she had ever been on her own, and she was very frightened. She did not know what to do. She could not go back to her parents because she had no money with her. She could not stay at the station because it was too cold. She could not go to the friends' house because she did not know where it was. She had to make a decision. She decided to go to a hotel. She found a hotel near the station and went in. She asked for a room. The hotel clerk looked at her and said that she was too young to stay in a hotel alone. She showed him her ticket and told him that she was waiting for a train. He said that she could wait in the lobby. So she sat down in the lobby and waited for the train. She waited for four hours. When the train arrived, she got on it. She was very tired and very cold. She had a very bad experience.